POST-COLONIAL THEATRE

The Festival Aesthetic and the Contemporary Stage

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

From the national festival to the Lagos fringe: how Nigerian theatre is funded, toured and staged now, and what the new plays are arguing about.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- national festivals
- university theatre
- the fringe
- funding
- new writing

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The festival as national form

Nigeria has used the festival as a instrument of cultural policy since the 1970s: the National Festival of Arts and Culture, the state arts councils, the university festivals and the religious festivals that draw the largest audiences of all. The festival gives a company a date, a venue, an audience and a reason to make a new work.

It also shapes the work: festival plays are short, portable, spectacular and easy to tour. That is not a corruption of the drama; it is a form with its own rules, and the best festival plays use them.

The university and the company

The university theatre departments remain the main producers of new Nigerian plays, and the companies that grew out of them - and out of the churches, the schools and the travelling theatres - make up the professional sector. The repertory is small, the runs are short, and the touring circuit is thin.

The economics explain the aesthetics: with no long runs, a play must earn its audience in one night, and the companies that survive have learned to combine a known title with a strong music and dance element.

The fringe and the new writing

The last two decades have produced a fringe: short-play festivals, poetry and performance nights, site-specific work in markets and courtyards, and a generation writing for small audiences in Lagos, Abuja, Port Harcourt and Enugu. The Lagos Theatre Festival, the Nigeria Theatre Festival and the proliferating campus festivals are its venues.

The new plays argue about money, gender, migration, the police, the internet and the family. They are more likely to be set in a flat than in a village, and more likely to be written for four actors than for twenty. That is a change in the theatre, not a decline in it.

What a student company should take from this

Make work that can travel: a small cast, a set that fits in a bus, a running time under ninety minutes, and a technical plan that works in a hall with one lighting bar. Enter every festival you can. Keep the script, the photographs and the programme; they are the record of a production that may never be reviewed.

The producer's checklist

For any festival or fringe performance, confirm in writing: the venue, the get-in and get-out times, the technical specification (power, lighting bars, sound inputs), the running time and any hard curfew, the fee and when it is paid, the accommodation and transport, the marketing materials the festival will produce, and who owns the recording.

Build a technical plan that fits in one page and one bag: what you bring, what you need, and what you can do without. Festivals run late and share equipment; a company that can perform with two lanterns and a laptop will always perform, and a company that needs a full rig will sometimes not.

Keep a festival file: the programme, the contract, the photographs, the reviews and the audience numbers. Funding applications ask for exactly this, and the company that has the file gets the grant.

The short run and the long life

A fringe production may play twice. That does not make it less serious; it makes the recording, the script, the photographs and the audience responses more important, because they are what survives.

Film the show with two cameras if you can, from the back and from the side, with the sound taken from the desk. A company without a recording of its own work is a company that starts from nothing every year.

Exercises

1. Plan a fringe production for a 60-seat venue: budget, cast, running time, technical plan.
2. Take a scene written for a large proscenium and reduce it to four actors and one bar of light.
3. Write a funding application for a new Nigerian play, one page, with a budget and an audience plan.

Where to read more

Awam Amkpa, Theatre and Postcolonial Desires (2004)

Tejumola Olaniyan, Scars of Conquest/Masks of Resistance (1995)

Femi Osofisan, The Nostalgic Drum (2001)

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